

### **“What If?” Analysis: An Unlikely Outcome in Yugoslavia, 1990.**

The possibility of muddling through is very low. In the unlikely event that it happens, this is what it would look like.

Memories of the internecine civil war during World War II and fear of another destructive conflict would lead the two most numerous South Slav people—Serbs and Croats—to reach some political accommodation. A compromise that preserves Yugoslavia would include:

- Basic principles:
  - No change in existing Republic borders.
  - No change in Yugoslavia’s existing international status.
  - Mutually recognized sovereignty of each republic
- Confederal institutions:
  - A single foreign ministry, to which diplomatic representatives would be accredited.
  - A central military organization with a joint General Staff responsible for planning.
  - A central bank, determining macroeconomic policy, a common currency,
- Powers reserved to republics.
  - Veto over actions of the Confederal Authority.
  - Control of internal security, including guarantee of minority rights.
  - Operational control over some or all military units stationed on the republic’s territory.
  - Raising taxes and allocating funds to discharge mutually agreed confederal responsibilities.

Only the Serbs can open the door to a confederal Yugoslavia, and Serbia’s leader, Slobodan Milosevic, holds the key. Some observers felt there are pressures on him to try. If he does not, he would give his opponents the leverage to remove him. The potential penalties of failure to compromise would be too great, in this view, for the peoples and leaders of Yugoslavia to forgo every effort to find a compromise.

—*Excerpts from the declassified NIE: Prospects for Yugoslavia, October 1990.*